

content gives it a dreamy consistency and flavor.

9. Shallots

This was an overlooked ingredient at my home. Until I accidentally planted a batch in my garden, I was unaware of the flavor and texture these little guys can bring to an ordinary recipe. Chuck Wilkins, of Reston, Virginia, agrees. After reading Anthony Bourdain's *Kitchen Confidential*, Chuck began to live by shallots. "They are inexpensive and their flavor is so much lighter and more complex than ordinary onions."

10. Citrus zest

Nothing gives your dishes a zip like the zest of oranges, lemons, and limes. Jill Nussinow, The Veggie Queen (TheVeggieQueen.com), calls it the "bonus ingredient" because you also get to use the juice!

11. Toasted nuts

Just about any nut can add some crunch and depth to your recipes. Julie Languille, who wrote *Meals in a Jar*, favors toasted hazelnuts, pine nuts, and almonds. She suggests adding a few tablespoons to salad and pasta for an extra special treat!

12. Bulk dried spices

The little spice containers from your local grocer aren't the best deal you could be getting (and their freshness is questionable). Stu Lustman, a financial writer, buys his favorite five or six dried spices in bulk to save money. They are perfect for rubs, but Stu also uses them in the same way as fresh herbs and spices. The trick? He pan-fries them slightly in a little oil to open up the flavor and adds them directly to his recipe.

This is by no means an exhaustive list of all the simple ingredients you can use to liven up your cooking, but it's a good place to start. Take a few and begin adding some lively and authentic flavor to your dishes. It won't cost you as much as you think!

— Linsey Knerl

